

An exploration into the ethics of Individuality as pioneered by John Stuart Mill in the life of Mr. Stevens' relationship with Ms. Kenton and Mr. Stevens Sr. in "The Remains of the Day" by Kazuo Ishiguro.

1. Introduction

The novel "The Remains of the Day" by Kazuo Ishiguro is the fictional personal account of a mid-20th century butler named Mr. Stevens as he travels across the English countryside to offer a working position to Mrs. Benn, previously Ms. Kenton. Along his travels he recounts the details of his journey, explores his view of his moral and professional obligations, and reminisces of the past happenings during his time attending to his late employer Lord Darlington. Throughout the journey he professes his view on topics such as proper employee and employer relations, the political obligations of members of a house, and what makes a good butler. His views of his undertakings as a butler of Darlington Hall both extend to his personal life and political views that while muddying his account of the past in his written records shed light into how he views himself as an individual. Along his travels Mr. Stevens recounts his view of his personal relationship with the housekeeper Ms. Kenton and his late father Mr. Stevens Sr..

John Stuart Mill was a 19th century philosopher who focused primarily on ethics, the mind, and liberty. According to John Stuart Mill individuality is an inherent fact of a person's disposition of which they can strive to enact in their life and model themselves after. Mill expresses that there is an ethical imperative for the good of society to allow others to have the liberty to act as they please as long as they do not hinder the liberty of other members of society. To Mill it is of the utmost importance that one

cannot cast judgement on another's way of life if it does not hinder another's liberty since judgement can only be cast if the person has experienced the judged way of life.

2. Exposition

Mr. Stevens regularly expresses his view of what makes a good butler and how he strove to hold himself to such standards as an individual. One common interpretation of Mill would be that Stevens' pursuit of being a great butler is warranted since that is what Stevens believes he should be. To Mill it would be fully in Stevens' right to act and dress as he does to uphold his chosen individuality of being a butler. The acts of Mr. Stevens fail to account for the views of others under the pretense of personal identity harming others, namely Ms. Kenton, Mr. Stevens Sr., and himself, by rejecting the obligation to respect others' views of events.

Stevens disrespected Ms. Kenton's right to individuality since in many of his accounts he disregards her beliefs on the basis of personal record. In one account he recalls:

"I was doing something in the library when Miss Kenton came in and said:

"Excuse me, Mr Stevens. But if you are searching for your dust-pan, it is out in the hall."

"I beg your pardon, Miss Kenton?"

"Your dust-pan, Mr Stevens. You've left it out here. Shall I bring it in for you?"

"Miss Kenton, I have not been using a dustpan."

"Ah, well, then forgive me, Mr Stevens. I naturally assumed you were using your dust-pan and had left it out in the hall. I am sorry to have disturbed you."

She started to leave, but then turned at the doorway and said: "Oh, Mr Stevens. I would return it myself but I have to go upstairs just now. I wonder if you will remember it?"

"Of course, Miss Kenton. Thank you for drawing attention to it."

"It is quite all right, Mr Stevens."

I listened to her footsteps cross the hall and start up the great staircase, then proceeded to the doorway myself. From the library doors, one has an unbroken view right across the entrance hall to the main doors of the house. Most conspicuously, in virtually the central spot of the otherwise empty and highly polished floor, lay the dustpan Miss Kenton had alluded to.

It struck me as a trivial, but irritating error; the dust-pan would have been conspicuous not only from the five ground-floor doorways opening on to the hall, but also from the staircase and the first-floor balconies. I crossed the hall and had actually picked up the offending item before realizing its full implication; my father, I recalled, had been brushing the entrance hall a half-hour or so earlier. At first, I found it hard to credit such an error to my father. But I soon reminded myself that such trivial slips are liable to befall anyone from time to time and my irritation soon turned to Miss Kenton for attempting to create such unwarranted fuss over the incident.””

This event like many others show that in Mr. Stevens attempts to hold his view of his father and him being at a standard of a butler that he was unable to perceive the validity of Ms. Kenton's worries. It could be understood that in his attempt to see his father as at a professional standard he neglected to respect Ms. Kenton's individual right to organize employees to clean the house. He also attempts to disregard Ms. Kenton's politeness in bringing up the transgression as out of her station since he sees his father to such high regard, even though it would be considered in her right as she manages the employees of the house.

His own disregard for attempting to understand reality is also exemplified by his attempt to neglect having political opinions as he reasons as what a good butler must do. His support for the actions of his previous employer Lord Darlington which he assumes to be how a great butler must be shown how he hopes to deny his obligation to perceive the world as truthful as he can. In denying the facts around him, such as denying that his father was becoming forgetful with age, he does not account for the beliefs of others since he assumes they should also give up their opinions as such their station requests of them.

Throughout the novel he recounts more and more of the personal interactions between Ms. Kenton and himself as it becomes more apparent that Ms. Kenton acted what would be easily seen as past professional care for Mr. Stevens whilst Mr. Stevens held an unexamined affection for Ms. Kenton. His

account attempted to hide and reason his choices as matters of profession instead of the simpler explanations of his affections for Ms. Kenton. These resigns of the facts both hurt Ms. Kenton by the fact of their dismissal and by their ramifications of distancing the closeness Ms. Kenton attempted to share with Mr. Stevens.

In the case of Mr. Stevens Sr., to which Mr. Stevens Jr. held in high regard as a model butler, there was a misjudgment of what Mr. Stevens Sr. wanted to engage and how Mr. Stevens Jr. treated him. While Mr. Stevens Sr. was on his deathbed and awaiting medical assistance he asked of Mr. Stevens Jr. to hear his hope that "... I've been a good father to you.". Mr. Stevens Jr. dismissed the comment while retreating into his view of himself as a butler with comments such as "I'm so glad you're feeling better now." and "I'm afraid we're extremely busy now, but we can talk again in the morning." Mr. Stevens Jr. in his hopes to be the model butler ignored the emotions of his father to complete his task of attending Lord Darlington's guests. On the same night his father passed, to which Mr. Stevens Jr. responded by attempting to rededicate himself to the task at hand with the Lords' company. In his recount of the events Steven Jr. holds that after that night he felt that he had achieved a new standard of being a better butler for which he believed his father would be proud. This shows that his pursuit to be a better butler both blinded him to be able to respond to his father before his father's death but also kept him from regarding what truly may have been his father's wishes. His father hoped to be more than that of a fellow butler to Stevens Jr. upon his passing but was diminished to an emotional challenge to be overcome by his son's pursuit holding the identity of a butler.

3. Objections and Replies

A strong possible rejection of whether Mr. Stevens disrespected others in his pursuit of individuality was that he never achieved or truly pursued Mill's conception of individuality. Another view of Mill's individuality is that to perceive individuality one must pursue a self identity different than that ever pursued to be true to one's self. This view would therefore imply that Stevens would be denying

himself in pursuing the position of what he considered an honorable butler. However, Stevens truly believed by his own account that he desired to be a great butler and this view would therefore deny his personal desires, no matter how restrictive it seems.

Another objection would be that Mr. Stevens was in his right as an individual to believe what he wanted as long as he did not directly harm others. For example, in the case of Ms. Kenton that she could have left Darlington Hall if the actions of Mr. Stevens were of such disregard for her personal feelings in their correspondence. A simple reply to this would be that Mr. Stevens may have had the right to be dismissive in his personal interactions with Ms. Kenton but would have no right to endanger her employed position at Darlington Hall based on his misguided belief of how his position should act.

One could argue that Mr. Stevens believed he was doing the best for others and the good of the world as a whole by neglecting to have an opinion and defer to his employers wishes. Stevens would therefore be no less moral than any other in his attempt to achieve individuality. Another way to express this is that Stevens is morally right in choosing to live the way he wants since he is “being himself” and not directly harming others. This differs from the previous objection as holding a stronger position that Stevens is within his right to dismiss the possible harm he imposes on others. This objection brings up the implications of whether it is morally right to deny the epistemological ramifications of Mill’s individuality. Mill would possibly respond by expanding on the definition of harming others and on the injustices of rejecting the reality of others. Treating others with respect to individuality would therefore be more than attempting to not harm them as oneself sees fit but also with the obligation to inquire how they would like to be treated. Stevens would therefore be incorrect in his actions towards Ms. Kenton in that he did not regard the rightful conclusion that his father was mentally aging since he disregarded her epistemological account of reality.

4. Conclusion

Mr. Stevens did not respect the individuality and beliefs of others in his pursuit of his own individuality as shown by his professional mismanagement of his father's decline, Ms. Kenton's professional management, and his own emotional dissonance with both Mr. Stevens Sr. and Ms. Kenton. His action not only harmed his potential connections but blinded himself to reality he shared with others. And though he may have achieved a semblance of Mill's understanding of individuality he did so in bad faith as he did not respect the individuality of Mr. Stevens Sr. and Ms. Kenton. Lastly, this story of Mr. Stevens helps to expose the underlying premise that supporters of liberty championed by Mill must accept is that though a very subjective individuality can be pursued one must consider the objective reality of others. Even though a chosen identity may not directly harm others, the ramifications of avoiding other's perspectives in pursuit of that identity may completely undermine the liberties of others. This novel brings attention to the crime of "Burying one's head in the sand" as more than a simple question of epistemological obligation but one of respecting the individuality of others.

5. Bibliography

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